

The goal is to get rid of your debt, not just simply close your eyes to it. Don't ignore your debt problems. First, you conquer the bad debt, and then you move on to the creation of wealth. Always keep that thought running in your mind, and it will help you through the unpleasant times of debt and debt collectors.

A common reaction to debt problems is avoidance. I hope you have learned by reading these pages so far that avoiding the issue does not make it go away. You will only make things worse in the long run, so don't bury your head in the sand. Don't sit at the bar and tell Joe to pour you another strong one. Taking action is the best thing to cure your debt and to boost your confidence.

## Lame Excuses

Don't dream up excuses to tell your creditors. You are not the one to blame, but you are the one who has the power to turn the tables. Lame excuses are what the creditors tell. Try asking a credit card customer service representative what a "membership fee" is and they will recite a paragraph of meaningless babble, instead of just telling you it is a way of charging you an annual fee without you knowing that you are paying an annual fee. Membership has its privileges. Or something like that.

Some of us, of a certain age, remember when the comedian Steve Martin had dark hair and an arrow through his head. He had a comedy bit where he promised to tell you how to be a millionaire and never pay taxes. That's right; how to be a millionaire and never pay taxes. "First, get a million dollars." Big laughs. "Then, when the Internal Revenue Service calls you up and says you have not paid your taxes, you simply say, 'I forgot!'"

The IRS certainly does not work that way and neither do your creditors. You have real reasons as to why you are having trouble paying your debts, but the real truth is that the lending institution really does not care what your reasons are. They want your money; not your excuses, not your stories, and not your jokes.

## The Next Battle

Ed and Sue's next-door neighbors, Steve and Maria, had fallen on hard times when they both suddenly lost their jobs. Steve and Maria